his endurance. Playing three-set-long matches and 50+ shot rallies is no longer as draining as it once was. "Post Olympics, I knew players are going to take it easy, some may retire or take an off, so my plan was to use the time to get into the top 15," he says. Sen is currently ranked #13 in the world.

Former hockey captain Viren Rasquinha, also CEO of OGQ, recently said that the next three years "will be the most important" of Sen's career. Since P.V. Sindhu will be 29 by the 2024 Paris Games, and Kidambi Srikanth, world silver medallist and currently India's highest ranked male player, 31, hopes are pinned on Sen to ensure India bags a medal like in the past three editions. Sen, though, is taking it one step at a time. "Playing in big tournaments like Asian Games will help me gain experience to play the Olympics in three years' time," he says.

He has the right people rallying for him. In December 2021, South Korean doubles specialist and Olympic medallist Yoo Yong-sung was appointed coach at PPBA. In 2018, D.K. Sen took voluntary retirement from his job as a coach at the Sports Authority of India, Almora, and moved to Bengaluru where he, too, took up a job as coach at the PPBA. With the kids having moved in with the family, D.K. Sen now ensures they get "*mummy ke haath ka khaana*" and spend limited time on their mobiles. "He needs to raise his fitness level so he can play against the retrievers," he says. "He would earlier attack a lot, now he is more patient and lets the rally unfold and then attack. If he can improve his attack, nobody can stop him." ■

–Suhani Singh

BRIGHTENING INDIA'S FUTURE

Grit and sacrifice have made possible Tasnim Mir's climb to the top of badminton's world U-19 rankings

Towards the end of last year, Tasnim Mir had a tough decision on her hands. She had turned 16 in May and had three more years to play on the junior circuit. At the same time, she thought it was the right moment to transition to the big league, in order to hone her skills against senior players. Through August and September, Mir played four international tournaments. She finished as the under-19 singles champion in Bulgaria, France and Belgium. The results convinced the then junior World No. 2 to aim higher. But there was, thankfully, a surprise in store for her last week.

Mir had just wrapped up her training session when her mother, Asma, informed her that as per the latest rankings, she was now the junior World No. 1. "It was completely unexpected. The rankings had been frozen due to Covid and I soon started playing on the senior circuit, so I didn't think I would make it to the top. But it was certainly something that I had thought of back when I started competing regularly," Mir says.

Mehsana in Gujarat, where Mir grew up, is best known for its many water parks. As a child, Mir remembers cooling off at these facilities during the summers. But those trips tapered off once she became a regular at the local badminton court. Her father, Irfan, gradually pushed her into a routine of sorts, doubling up as her first coach. The spark in her was evident when she was crowned the under-13 state champion, even before she hit her teens. "I started skipping classes to dedicate more time to training. Even today, I don't have thick friends. We also didn't take many vacations as a family. All our efforts were focused on badminton," Mir says.

At her first national championship, aged 11, she was spotted by Pullela Gopichand, who invited her to train at his academy in Hyderabad. Ever since, the family has lived separately so that Mir can chase her dream. "My father would look after my younger brother in Mehsana, while my mother travels with me. It isn't just me who has made sacrifices," she says.

In December 2017, she shifted base to the Assam Badminton Academy in Guwahati to train under Edwin Iriawan, an Indonesian coach, who has worked with the Indian national team in the past. Under the doubles specialist, Mir also started playing mixed doubles with her partner, Ayan Rashid. Her first international triumph came at the Dubai International Series in 2019. After two other titles, Covid brought a halt to her progress. She took the time to finish her Class 10 examination. "I stopped going to school from Class 7. All my studies have been online since."

These days, her brother, Mohammed Ali, also a promising shuttler, has shifted base to Guwahati to train at the academy. It has brought the family closer, though her father still works in Mehsana. "We chat over the phone every day. My father is still very involved with my game. We know that I have got a long way to go to be among the best," she says. ■

–Shail Desai



NOW 16, JUNIOR BADMINTON STAR TASNIM MIR IS TRANSITIONING TO THE BIG LEAGUE AND HONING HER SKILLS AGAINST SENIOR PLAYERS